

Task 5: Part A

Case Study: UPI/Online Payment Fraud

UPI (Unified Payments Interface) fraud is a rapidly growing cybercrime in which attackers trick users into transferring money or revealing sensitive banking details. This type of fraud commonly occurs through social engineering techniques.

A typical scenario begins when a fraudster contacts the victim via phone, SMS, or messaging apps, posing as a bank official, customer care agent, or even a buyer/seller on an online marketplace. Step-by-step, the attacker first builds trust by using convincing language and sometimes partial personal information. Next, they send a payment request or a malicious link, claiming it is needed to “receive money” or “verify an account.” The victim is then instructed to enter their UPI PIN, unknowingly authorizing a debit transaction instead of a credit. In some cases, screen-sharing apps are used to gain access to the victim’s phone and banking apps.

The primary targets are individuals who are less familiar with digital payments, such as elderly users, new smartphone users, or people in urgent financial situations. Small business owners and online sellers are also frequent victims.

The consequences can be severe, including immediate financial loss, emotional distress, and difficulty recovering funds. Additionally, victims may lose trust in digital payment systems. This highlights the importance of awareness, as legitimate platforms never require a PIN to receive money, and users should always verify requests before proceeding.